



Thrissur Titans players lift the trophy to celebrate their victory against the Calicut Globstars in the Kerala Cricket League Final match at the Greenfield International Cricket stadium, in Thiruvananthapuram

THRISSUR'S YOUNG BRIGADE CONQUERS KCL SEASON 3

The third edition of the Kerala Cricket League (KCL) marked the end of 'reputation bias' inherent in Keralam T20 cricket. The final was contested between two teams who had never won titles before- Thrissur Titans and Calicut Globstars - with the Titans ultimately emerging as the new T20 champion of Keralam.

The Titans' triumph was a vindication of its brave youth policy which prioritised unheralded rookies over established stars. The young turks had routinely pulled off thrilling last over wins in the league and it was no different in the final. The Titans gave their fans a few jitters, and won the final overcoming a brief stutter.

Chasing 168, a decisive 87-run partnership between Ahammed



Imran (69) and Sanjeev Satheesan (29) put the Titans on the path to victory. However, the Globstars' Jose Perayil triggered a mini collapse by picking up two wickets in the 16th over. It was left to the cool and wiser head of captain M.S.Akhil (19 not out

off 11 balls), who slammed Ibnul Afthab for a boundary, to seal the title with three balls to spare. The 36-year-old Akhil was the oldest player in Titans' team whose average age was 23. Ahammed Imran was the most consistent player for Titans and underlined his reputation as the next big star in Kerala cricket. Sarath Chandra Prasad and P.Abdul Ramees were two rookie bowlers who stepped up for Thrissur in the league.

Sarath weaponised the short ball

effectively against big hitters in the tournament and was excellent during the PowerPlay and at the death overs. Sarath's performance saw him fast tracked into the Keralam team for the Oman tour and was one of the success stories of the KCL.

Ramees made the transition from tennis ball to leather ball cricket fairly quickly. He was crafty with good variations and was deceptively quick. The two pacers were the stand out performers of season 3.

The Titans' coach Sunil Kumar said the strategy during the auction was to go for rookies and young talent as the team wanted to avoid the 'square pegs in round holes' trap that plagued other franchises. This approach required taking major risks like asking the 18-year-old K.R. Rohit to open